Kashmiris, when it was Pakistan's new generation of hardliners who wanted to undo Kashmir's Sufi traditions in the first place. Thus, the start of the phase of Operation Topac was now in place, that is, to turn Kashmiris away from their centuries-old culture of Sufism by replacing it with hard-line Wahhabi Islam and cleansing the valley of non-Muslims like the Pandits.

Wahhabi Islam Shapes the Insurgency

With the growing influence of Wahhabi Islam, a more fundamental Islam has grown in Kashmir, especially since 2000, following the setting up of thousands of Wahhabi *Mullah*-led mosques that many say were funded by Saudi Arabia and their representatives in Pakistan. Though their growth—in thousands—had been noticeable for years, as their architecture differed from the earlier types of mosques, these were passively allowed to grow by political parties in Kashmir. These mosques not only served as gathering places for locals, but they soon began to be used by politicians for their speeches and by hard-line *mullahs* for their (often anti-India) sermons. Today, large sections of the Kashmiris in the valley appear to be sympathetic—either by choice or coercion—to the more fundamental ways of Islam. The fear of Pakistan's intelligence agencies (such as the ISI) and the targeted assassinations of those who dared to challenge their narrative have left the moderates with no choice but to silently abide by such norms being enforced.

A large number of youth, who are victims of disruptions to their education and social life due to the battles against militancy and with few opportunities to earn a living, have been recruited into stone-pelting mobs, often getting paid as little as 100 rupees a day. They are egged on by local politicians and the Hurriyat leaders to attack police and paramilitary men on patrols or to disrupt counter-insurgency operations by giving cornered militants an exit route. Drawing upon an old and local tradition of stone pelting and the model of the Palestinian Intifada, they have challenged the patience of Indian troops. Many policemen were injured by these stone-pelting mobs which forced them to use pellet guns in response, in order to